

Speaking Up

Vocabulary, Grammar, and Comprehension Handout

Intermediate Level

THE TEXT

Note: This version improves clarity and flow while preserving the original voice and meaning.

I don't know why, but it has always been hard for me to tell others what I need, especially when it comes to managers or my boss. Even when something at work bothers me, I tend to stay quiet and just deal with it on my own. I guess that is the reason why, despite having endless complaints at work, I kept them all to myself instead of letting my manager know how I truly felt. Part of me was afraid of being seen as difficult, and another part simply did not know how to bring it up.

But today, I did something different — not because I suddenly found the courage, but because if I did not stand up for myself this time, I would be stuck on the night shift next month without the chance of saying no. The thought of going through an entire month of exhausting late hours pushed me to finally speak up. After discussing the difficulties I had been facing with my manager, he told me he would bring it up with the head of my department and assured me not to worry too much.

Before talking to him, my mind had been racing for hours, imagining all the ways he might dismiss my request. I had convinced myself that he would say no without even considering my situation. But his response took me in a completely different direction — one I had never expected. Instead of shutting me down, he listened carefully and showed genuine concern.

It made me wonder about all the hard moments in the past — the times I felt tired, exhausted, and frustrated by what seemed like unreasonable rules in my department. Perhaps what I needed to do all along was simply walk up to him and express what I was going through. Instead, I chose silence, and the result of never taking action was bearing all the unfairness in the workplace alone and feeling completely helpless. All those sleepless nights and bitter feelings could have been avoided if I had just opened my mouth sooner.

Though I am not fully relieved yet, I am glad that I took a step forward. Looking back, I realize the hardest part was not the conversation itself but the fear I had built up in my mind beforehand. Maybe expressing my needs is just another skill that takes practice — and today was my first real lesson.

PART A: VOCABULARY (12 Words)

Study the following vocabulary words from the text. Pay attention to how each word is used in context.

#	Word	Definition & Example from Text
1	bother (v.)	to cause someone to feel annoyed or troubled. "Even when something at work bothers me, I tend to stay quiet."
2	tend to (phr. v.)	to usually do something; to have a habit of doing something. "I tend to stay quiet and just deal with it on my own."
3	complaint (n.)	a statement that something is wrong or unsatisfactory. "Despite having endless complaints at work, I kept them all to myself."
4	stand up for (phr. v.)	to defend or support yourself or your beliefs. "If I did not stand up for myself this time..."
5	exhausting (adj.)	making you feel extremely tired. "The thought of going through an entire month of exhausting late hours."
6	speak up (phr. v.)	to express your opinion or needs openly. "...pushed me to finally speak up."
7	assure (v.)	to tell someone something confidently to remove their doubt. "He assured me not to worry too much."

8	dismiss (v.)	to reject or refuse to consider something. "Imagining all the ways he might dismiss my request."
9	convince (v.)	to cause someone to believe something firmly. "I had convinced myself that he would say no."
10	genuine (adj.)	truly what it appears to be; sincere. "He listened carefully and showed genuine concern."
11	frustrated (adj.)	feeling upset or annoyed because you cannot change or achieve something. "The times I felt tired, exhausted, and frustrated."
12	relieved (adj.)	feeling happy because something unpleasant has stopped or has not happened. "Though I am not fully relieved yet."

Vocabulary Practice 1: Multiple Choice

Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

1. She didn't want to _____ her teacher with too many questions.

- a) assure
- b) bother
- c) dismiss
- d) convince

2. When you feel something is unfair, you should _____ yourself.

- a) tend to
- b) speak up for
- c) stand up for
- d) assure

3. The manager tried to _____ the team that their jobs were safe.

- a) dismiss
- b) frustrate
- c) convince
- d) assure

4. The long hike was _____, but the view from the top was worth it.

- a) genuine
- b) relieved
- c) exhausting
- d) frustrated

5. He felt _____ after the doctor said the test results were normal.

- a) frustrated
- b) dismissed
- c) exhausting
- d) relieved

6. She _____ eat lunch at the same café every day.

- a) speaks up
- b) tends to
- c) stands up for
- d) bothers

7. The boss chose to _____ the employee's suggestion without discussion.

- a) assure
- b) convince
- c) dismiss
- d) relieve

8. I could tell her smile was _____; she was truly happy for me.

- a) exhausting
- b) frustrated
- c) dismissed
- d) genuine

Vocabulary Practice 2: Fill in the Blanks

Complete each sentence with the correct word from the box.

<i>speaking up</i>	<i>complaints</i>	<i>convinced</i>	<i>frustrated</i>	<i>standing up for</i>	<i>tend to</i>
		<i>relieved</i>	<i>bother</i>		

1. Many employees have _____ about the new schedule, but nobody has said anything to the manager.
2. She _____ herself that everything would be fine, even though she was nervous.
3. It took him a long time to _____ in meetings, but now he shares his ideas freely.
4. People who _____ avoid conflict often keep their feelings inside.
5. After weeks of waiting, she finally got the news and felt extremely _____.
6. He felt _____ because no matter how hard he tried, the system never changed.
7. Does the noise from the construction site _____ you at night?
8. A good friend will always _____ you when others treat you unfairly.

PART B: GRAMMAR (4 Patterns)

Study the following grammar structures from the text.

Pattern 1: "not... but because..."

Form: not because + clause, but because + clause

Use: To correct a wrong assumption and give the real reason.

Example from text: *"Not because I suddenly found the courage, but because if I did not stand up for myself this time, I would be stuck on the night shift."*

More examples:

- I didn't quit the job not because I enjoyed it, but because I needed the income.
- She chose that university not because of the location, but because of its strong science program.
- He apologized not because he was wrong, but because he valued the friendship.

Pattern 2: "the result of + gerund + was..."

Form: The result of + gerund + was + gerund / noun phrase

Use: To describe the consequence of a habitual action or choice.

Example from text: *"The result of never taking action was bearing all the unfairness in the workplace alone."*

More examples:

- The result of not studying was failing the final exam.
- The result of exercising daily was a noticeable improvement in her health.
- The result of ignoring the warning signs was a costly mistake.

Pattern 3: "could have been + past participle"

Form: Subject + could have been + past participle (+ if clause)

Use: To talk about something that was possible in the past but did not happen.

Example from text: *"All those sleepless nights and bitter feelings could have been avoided if I had just opened my mouth sooner."*

More examples:

- The accident could have been prevented if the driver had paid attention.
- She could have been promoted if she had applied for the position.
- The misunderstanding could have been cleared up if they had talked to each other.

Pattern 4: "Perhaps what I needed to do was + verb"

Form: Perhaps what + subject + needed/need to do + was/is + (to) verb

Use: To reflect on a better course of action, often after realizing a past mistake.

Example from text: *"Perhaps what I needed to do all along was simply walk up to him and express what I was going through."*

More examples:

- Perhaps what she needed to do was take a break instead of pushing herself harder.
- Perhaps what we need to do is listen more and talk less.
- Perhaps what he needed to do was ask for help instead of doing everything alone.

Grammar Practice 1: Multiple Choice

Choose the best answer to complete each sentence.

1. She moved to the city not because she wanted to, _____ because her company transferred her.

- a) and
- b) so
- c) but
- d) or

2. The result of not sleeping enough _____ poor performance at work.

- a) is
- b) was
- c) were
- d) are

3. The project _____ finished on time if we had started earlier.

- a) could be
- b) could have been
- c) can be
- d) can have been

4. Perhaps what he needed to do _____ apologize instead of making excuses.

- a) is
- b) were
- c) was
- d) been

5. I chose this school not because it was close, _____ because it had the best program.

- a) and
- b) so
- c) or
- d) but

6. The mistake could _____ corrected if someone had spoken up sooner.

- a) be
- b) been
- c) have been
- d) had been

7. The result of practicing every day _____ a significant improvement in her skills.

- a) were
- b) was
- c) are
- d) have been

8. Perhaps what we need to do _____ slow down and rethink our plan.

- a) was
- b) were
- c) is
- d) are

Grammar Practice 2: Sentence Transformation

Rewrite each sentence using the pattern indicated in parentheses.

not... but because...

1. I didn't stay home because I was lazy. The real reason was that I was sick. (I stayed home not because...)

2. She didn't cry because she was sad. She cried because she was so happy. (She cried not because...)

the result of + gerund + was...

3. He never practiced, so he failed the audition. (The result of...)

4. She saved money every month, so she was able to buy a car. (The result of...)

could have been + past participle

5. They didn't book early, so they lost the reservation. (The reservation could...)

6. Nobody checked the schedule, and the meeting was missed. (The meeting could...)

Perhaps what... needed to do was...

7. He kept complaining but never talked to his boss. (Perhaps what he needed to do...)

8. She felt lonely but never reached out to anyone. (Perhaps what she needed to do...)

PART C: COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS

Answer the following questions based on the text.

Tier 1: Literal Understanding

1. What has the author always found difficult to do?
2. What would happen if the author did not speak to the manager?
3. How did the manager respond after hearing about the author's difficulties?

Tier 2: Inference & Analysis

4. Why do you think the author chose to stay silent about work complaints in the past?
5. The author says the manager's calm response "caught me off guard." What does this tell us about the author's expectations before the conversation?
6. What does the author mean by "the hardest part was not the conversation itself but the fear I had built up in my mind beforehand"?

Tier 3: Critical Thinking

7. The author compares expressing needs to a skill that takes practice. Do you think this is an accurate comparison? Why or why not?
8. Do you think the author would have spoken up if the situation had been less urgent — for example, if the night shift were optional? Explain your reasoning.

Tier 4: Personal Response

9. Have you ever been in a situation where you wanted to say something but chose to stay silent? What happened as a result?
10. If you were in the author's position, would you have handled the conversation with the manager differently? How?

PART D: CONVERSATION QUESTIONS

Discuss the following questions with a partner or in small groups. Let the conversation flow naturally from one question to the next.

Theme: Speaking Up for Yourself

1. Do you find it easy or difficult to express your needs to people in positions of authority, such as a boss, a teacher, or a doctor? Why do you think that is?
2. Some people believe that staying quiet at work is the safest option, while others think speaking up leads to better results. Which approach do you lean toward, and has it worked well for you?
3. Think of a time when you finally spoke up about something that had been bothering you for a long time. What pushed you to do it, and how did it turn out?
4. The author discovered that the fear of the conversation was worse than the conversation itself. Have you ever experienced something similar in any area of your life?
5. Do you think culture or upbringing plays a role in how comfortable people are with expressing their needs? In what way?
6. Some people rehearse what they want to say before a difficult conversation, while others prefer to speak naturally in the moment. Which do you do, and why?
7. Have you ever regretted not speaking up about something? What would you say now if you could go back to that moment?
8. The author says that expressing needs is a skill that takes practice. What other life skills do you think people often overlook but should actively practice?
9. If a close friend told you they were afraid to talk to their boss about a problem at work, what advice would you give them?
10. Do you think workplaces should do more to encourage employees to share their concerns openly? What would that look like in practice?

ANSWER KEY

Vocabulary Practice 1: Multiple Choice

1. b) bother 2. c) stand up for 3. d) assure 4. c) exhausting 5. d) relieved 6. b) tends to 7. c) dismiss 8. d) genuine

Vocabulary Practice 2: Fill in the Blanks

1. complaints 2. convinced 3. speak up 4. tend to 5. relieved 6. frustrated 7. bother 8. stand up for

Grammar Practice 1: Multiple Choice

1. c) but 2. b) was 3. b) could have been 4. c) was 5. d) but 6. c) have been 7. b) was 8. c) is

Grammar Practice 2: Sentence Transformation (Sample Answers)

1. I stayed home not because I was lazy, but because I was sick.
2. She cried not because she was sad, but because she was so happy.
3. The result of never practicing was failing the audition.
4. The result of saving money every month was being able to buy a car.
5. The reservation could have been kept if they had booked early.
6. The meeting could have been attended if someone had checked the schedule.
7. Perhaps what he needed to do was talk to his boss instead of complaining.
8. Perhaps what she needed to do was reach out to someone instead of staying silent.

Comprehension Questions (Sample Answers)

1. The author has always found it difficult to tell others, especially managers, what they need.
2. The author would be sent to the night shift next month without the chance of saying no.
3. The manager said he would bring it up with the head of the department and assured the author not to worry too much.
4. The author was afraid of being seen as difficult and did not know how to bring up complaints.
5. It tells us the author expected the manager to reject the request or react negatively, so the calm and understanding response was surprising.
6. It means the author spent more energy worrying about what might happen than the actual conversation required, suggesting the fear was exaggerated.
7. Answers will vary based on personal opinion.
8. Answers will vary based on personal opinion.
9. Answers will vary based on personal experience.
10. Answers will vary based on personal experience.

Conversation Questions

Answers will vary. These questions are designed for open discussion.